THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION
PARIS BRANCH

NEWSLETTER
SEPTEMBER 2010

Chairman's Report

That this is a Bumper edition demonstrates the health of the Paris Branch. This is due to the tireless work of your Committee. Here you will find something for everyone - starting with the Subscriptions reminder ! There are the details of the Club Lunches, the Poppy Coffee Morning, and the next Battlefield Tour, this time to Tunisia. Those with a taste for history will be attracted to the books recommended by Joan Hicks and Rosemary Bateau-Chubb. Each has a personal relevance for our two lady members. "Massacre on the Marne" relates the exploits of the Regiment in which Rosemary's father served (the 2nd/5th West Yorkshires). While Joan's is the diary of a lady who, like our stalwarts Joan and Carmen Thourot, was captured in 1940 as an alien and deported to Besançon.

As our Membership Secretary reports in his attached letter on Subscriptions your Committee is always greatly impressed by the financial, and therefore moral, support of those members who cannot make the visit to the Clubhouse for personal reasons, but who are with us in spirit. We are greatly indebted to them.

This autumn we are preparing a membership drive aimed at those members of the British Community here in the Paris area who have expressed their support for our principles. Perhaps you know of some friends or neighbours who you think might respond favourably to such an approach and agree to become members. If so please do not hesitate to get in touch with me and supply me with the details of the people you have in mind.

Next Year we celebrate the 90th anniversary of the formation of the Paris Branch in May 1921, our own foundation pre-dating that of the British Legion shortly afterwards. Your Committee is reviewing what form our celebration should take and we hope you will participate whole-heartedly in this milestone event.

"We will remember them"

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NEWS FROM THE SECRETARY

Welcome back. It does not seem that long ago that we were planning for our summer break, now we find ourselves planning for the coming months with various ceremonies and of course The Poppy Appeal.

On the Social side of Legion life we have arranged dates for Club lunches in October and November. Why not September, I hear you ask. Due to proposed strikes on the RER, SNCF and Buses, and our resident cook, Tony Bennett, being absent for part of September, we decided the best option was to have two lunches in October, one at the start and the second at the end of the month. Please see the attached article and reply slip with this Newsletter. In December we will have the Christmas lunch and dinner also mentioned in the same article.

Our new financial year begins on 1st October and of course this means renewal of subscriptions once again. Our Membership Secretary, Mark Yates has included the subs reminder form with this Newsletter.

Two of our Members, Rosemary Bateau-Clubb and Joan Hicks have asked us to include two flyers for books that they are keen to promote. Please see the enclosed.

Next year marks the 90th Anniversary of the foundation of The British Legion, as it was in 1921. We would like to hold a Dinner Dance sometime between May and July. The date is not set in concrete yet. We would open this event to Members, friends and members of the British Community to help us celebrate this milestone in our history. As many of you know, the Paris branch of the RBL was formed on 13th May 1921. This was some weeks before the formation in London which began on 1st July 1921. It would be good to get your feed back to this proposed event. Please write to me, Janet Warby, at the Legion, 28 rue des Acacias, 75017 Paris, giving your thoughts and whether you would like to join us in the event. Let's make this a great evening, one to be remembered.

As I said at the beginning of this letter, we will soon be into the Poppy Appeal. If you would like to help with the selling of Poppies or know of any new outlets where we could put a poppy box, please let me or our Poppy Organiser, Joyce Gilhooley – 01 43 21 57 20 – know. Our Annual Poppy Coffee Morning at the Ambassador's Residence will be held on Tuesday 2nd November, 10h30 – 12h00. Please see the enclosed flyer for this event.

We are planning the Annual Service of Remembrance at The Cathedral of Notre Dame de Paris, which this year falls on a Thursday. The time of the Service is 15h00 in the presence of H.M. Ambassador to Paris, Sir Peter Westmacott, Commonwealth Ambassadors, French VIP's, Members of the British Community, British and French Ex-Service Associations. All those wishing to attend should be seated no later than 14h40. We hope to see as many of you there as possible.

Janet Warby
Hon Secretary



SUBSCRIPTIONS 2010-2011

Dear Member,

October approaches and once more I'm pecking at the keyboard here to remind you that – yes already ! - it is time to reach for your cheque book and fork out your annual subscription to the RBL Paris Branch because our year starts on 1st October.

You will be glad to hear that, once again, we have managed to avoid increasing subscriptions. They are as follows:

- 25 to 64 years old €46 Euros
- 65 and over €37 Euros
- 25 and under €21 Euros

Our new HQ in Rue des Acacias has got off the ground well this year and monthly lunches there have quickly become popular. Your committee is now able to relax over its coffee, safe in the knowledge that the premises conform to safety standards for such events. Thus, even if Tony decides to do crêpes suzettes (and we all know what is likely to happen if a flame approaches what he would consider a sufficient dose of cognac), we won't be reduced to lowering wheel-chair-bound members from the second floor on the end of a rope improvised from our secretary's lovely curtains to escape the inferno.

Other events have also been successful, notably our annual rekindling of the flame at the Arc de Triomphe when our guests, the Pakistani ambassador and military attaché presented the Branch with an impressive chess set and an even more impressive knife. With his invariable cheerfulness he tactfully refrained from suggesting what we should do with the latter (you will recall the reaction of the ambassador's government to Mr Cameron's comments in India the previous week)

More events are coming up, not least the trip to Tunisia and the North African battle sites. And of course the poppy appeal season is almost upon us, a busy time for all: some members have requested a small stock of poppies for distribution in local bars and shops. Should you have any ideas along those lines, don't hesitate to ask...

Please continue to support us in the coming year: Demands on the RBL's resources are increasing rather than otherwise. This is the case in general, as the results of more recent conflicts trickle through and, more locally, as ex-servicemen retired in France run into difficulties because of investment and exchange problems of which you will be aware.

I always feel we should be particularly grateful to those of you who, in spite of being unable to participate personally in our activities, either because you live far away or because of failing health, continue to support the RBL for the best of all reasons – that it is a worthwhile charity whose actions really make a difference. Thank you.

You can send any information to mfyates@gmail.com or to paris@rblfrance.org which is our official email address. Our website can be consulted at http://www.rblfrance.org/ Don't forget; you can also check events etc. on the site.

Subscription forms are included with this newsletter. I look forward to hearing from you

Please do try and let me have your subscription promptly

Best regards

Mark Yates

Membership secretary

Cher Adhérent,

A l'approche de la fin septembre je me trouve, encore une fois, en train de picoter au clavier pour vous rappeler une fois de plus – oui déjà ! – que l'heure est arrivée de sortir votre carnet de chèques, prendre votre courage à deux mains et débourser la somme nécessaire pour acquitter votre cotisation annuelle. Effectivement, l'année RBL commence le 1er octobre.

Vous serez heureux d'apprendre que, une fois de plus, nous avons pu éviter d'augmenter les cotisations qui restent, donc de :

- 25 à 64 ans € 46 Euros
- 65 et plus € 37 Euros
- 25 ans et moins € 21 Euros

Notre nouveau QG, rue des Acacias s'est bien lancé cette année et les déjeuners mensuels sont rapidement devenus populaires. Votre comité peut maintenant se détendre autour de son café, enfin confiant que les lieux se conforment aux normes de sûreté exigés pour de tels événements. Ainsi, nous sommes prêts même pour le jour ou Tony décide de flamber des crêpes suzettes (et nous savons tous ce qui risque de se produire si une flamme approche une dose de cognac suffisant dans ses yeux pour faire une flambée). Il ne sera plus nécessaire de descendre nos membres en fauteuils roulants par la fenêtre accrochés aux cordes improvisés à partir des beaux rideaux de notre secrétaire pour qu'ils échappent à l'incendie.

D'autres événements ont également réussi, notamment la réanimation annuelle de la flamme à l'Arc de Triomphe. Nos invités, lAmbassadeur et l'Attaché de Défense pakistanais nous ont présenté un magnifique jeu d'echèques et un couteau non moins impressionnant. Avec sa bonne humeur habituelle Monsieur l'Ambassadeur, plein de tact s'est abstenu de suggérer ce que nous devrions faire avec ce dernier (vous vous souvenez, peut-être, de la réaction de son gouvernement aux commentaires de M. Cameron la semaine précédente, aux Indes)

D'autres évènements se profilent à l'horizon, parmi eux, et non pas le moindre sera un voyage en Tunisie avec visite des sites de combat en Afrique de nord. Et naturellement la saison du « Poppy Appeal » arrive aux grand pas, une période très occupée pour tout le monde ici. D'ailleurs, quelques membres ont demandé de petites quantités des « poppies » pour distribution dans des bars et des boutiques locaux. Si vous voyez des possibilités semblables, n'hésitez pas à demander...

Continuez, s'il vous plaît, à nous soutenir l'année prochaine : Les demandes faites sur les ressources de la RBL augmentent plutôt que le contraire. C'est le cas en général, car les conséquences des conflits récents commencent à se faire ressentir, tandis que, plus localement, certains anciens combattants, retraités en France subissent des difficultés qui découlent des problèmes financiers et des taux d'échange.

Je pense toujours que nous devons saluer plus particulièrement ceux de vous que, malgré l'incapacité de participer personnellement à nos activités, soit parce que vous êtes loin de Paris, soit pour des raisons de santé, continuent à soutenir la RBL pour la meilleure raison que soit – le fait que ce soit une charité dont les actions font vraiment une différence à des gens dans le besoin. Merci.

Pour tout renseignement, vous pouvez me contacter à mfyates@gmail.com ou à paris@rblfrance.org , cette dernière étant notre adresse officielle attachée à notre site web que vous pouvez consulter à http://www.rblfrance.org/

Vous trouverez ci-joint le formulaire d'adhésion à remplir et à renvoyer avec votre abonnement 2010-2011.
A bientôt...

Bien cordialement

Mark Yates
Membership secretary



THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION
PARIS BRANCH

CLUB LUNCHES

OCTOBER

Wednesday 6th

12h15 for 12h30. Three course lunch which includes Kir and Coffee.
Wine or other drinks to be obtained from the bar and paid for seperately.
Price €15 per person

Thursday 28th

12h15 for 12h30. Three course lunch which includes Kir and Coffee.
Wine or other drinks to be obtained from the bar and paid for seperately.
Price €15 per person

NOVEMBER

Thursday 25th

12h15 for 12h30. Three course lunch which includes Kir and Coffee.
Wine or other drinks to be obtained from the bar and paid for seperately.
Price €15 per person

DECEMBER

Wednesday 15th

Christmas Lunch

12h15 for 12h30. Three course Christmas lunch which includes Kir, half a bottle of Wine per person and Coffee.
Price €30 per person

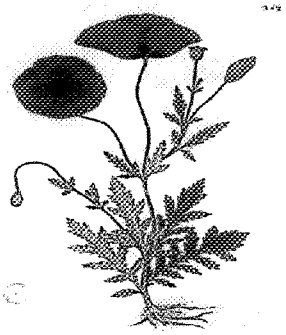
Friday 17th

Christmas Dinner

19h00 for 19h30. Three course Christmas dinner which includes Kir, half a bottle of Wine per person and Coffee.
Price €30 per person

The Tombola draw will take place at 18h00.

Please complete the enclosed slip stating the dates of Club lunches and Christmas lunch or Dinner should you wish to join us. Guests are invited but please be advised numbers are limited, so first come first served.



EARL HAIG POPPY APPEAL 2010

LADY WESTMACOTT, wife of H.M. Ambassador to France,

has kindly accepted to host a Coffee Morning

in aid of the Poppy Appeal

which the ROYAL BRITISH LEGION, PARIS BRANCH,

organizes every year for the benefit of the

EARL HAIG BENEVOLENT FUND

The Coffee Morning will take place at

THE BRITISH AMBASSADOR'S RESIDENCE

39 rue du Faubourg St. Honoré,

PARIS 8éme

TUESDAY 2nd NOVEMBER, 2010

10h30 - 12 noon

Please send your stamped addressed envelope to :
Miss Joan Hicks
6 rue des Petits Prés
78810 Feucherolles

An invitation card for presentation at the entrance will be sent to you. This event is free of charge. Donations welcome. I.D. Cards or Passports required. Numbers limited. Date limit 26/10/2010

BATTLEFIELD TOUR OF TUNISIA: 21st-24th October 2010

OUR TOUR GUIDE: by Roger Thorn

Those of you who have been treated to one of Colonel Oliver Warman's battlefield tours will vouch for the stimulating experience that it was. For those members he requires no introduction. His enthusiasm is tangible. For others for whom Tunisia is the first tour with him it will be helpful to hear something of his background.

After Sandhurst, the Welsh Guards and Staff College, where he was later himself an instructor, he was advised by his Colonel to consider a degree course while waiting for promotion. This he took up and read Military History at Balliol College, Oxford, where his thesis covered the drop on Arnhem. His apparently right-wing profile attracted many a jibe from undergraduates in the Balliol Junior Common Room, many years his junior. His favourite was the cry one morning as he came down for breakfast: " Good morning Oliver. Have you killed anyone today ?" He was doubtless tempted to reply: "No, not yet". With subsequent experience in intelligence he worked in 10, Downing Street as Intelligence Advisor to the then Prime Minister, a Grenadier Guardsman, Harold MacMillan.

Under Oliver's banner we have visited: Normandy, Dunkirk, Dieppe and Bruneval, the Somme, Ypres, Arnhem and Monte Cassino. We are certain to be both entertained and instructed when we accompany him to Tunisia.

In his rare moments of free time Oliver is a distinguished artist, being a member of the Royal Society of British Artists.

THE TUNISIAN CAMPAIGN
by Colonel Oliver Warman

This tour is to be the story of a mongrel Army which grew to magnificence in the Tunisian Desert - it is the story, mainly, of the 78 th Division which many have called the finest fighting division within the Allied forces. It is the story also of their American allies who were learning, for the second time, what European war was like, and it is the story of short-term Vichy French intransigence for an even shorter term gain, of political confusion in the back alleys of Algiers (which was to be repeated, in the late 1950s for those who read really good novels, in that very popular book "The Day of the Jackal" describing the many attempted assasinations of President de Gaulle). Many centuries before, the Greeks, the Phoenicians and the Romans, brave men all of them, landed in their small boats on this fierce continent - there was no welcome for them either, the continental edge threatens and warns, then turns away with a shrug of rocky shoulders - and so it was to be for the Allies...except for the Vichy French, who were there and backing our, yes, our enemy. On that November day Oran was the first serious stop, grey, dusty but enlivened by tribes of monkeys who did what looked like physical training exercises on the airport roof. Algiers, the planned command centre was different, calm green fields and vineyards (their grapes so often toughened up for bringing the cost down of indifferent Bordeaux wine until the fraud squads took over in the 1970s). Above the city stood a large villa occupied by General Giraud (twice take prisoner by the Germans and twice escaped, the second time into the embrace of Petain to whom he promised that he would ignore de Gaulle, but not be a collaborationist like Darlan (assasinated shortly before this tale begins) who was, shall we say, a despicable political

opportunist and a manifestation of the Vichy French Navy's deep dislike for the British. Interestingly he took the long view thinking it possible that he might, just might, have to use North Africa as a bolt hole - with this in mind he used his powers within the Vichy government to lay the foundations of a Fascist state and a pro-Darlan state at that. The true French patriots were thrown into concentration camps, the civil service was pruned and a steady stream of pro-axis propaganda flooded N. Africa supported by an ever-increasing spearhead of Gestapo agents. He was no politician, which proved a sad hindrance to the French cause. In short, for the political expedience of the Allies, Darlan and the newly arrived Giraud, after the invasion, took over what appeared to be a joint Vice-Consulship, balancing the Vichy French and Allied atitudes as best they could to the indifferent regard of the farmers and townspeople similar to, say, the majority of the population of Algeria in the 1950s. The ready-to-jump allies were headed after the initial invasion by General Eisenhower, whose fundamental honesty impressed everybody. And lastly, before looking at what we might see of the battle, let us mention the two resident civilian Ministers under Eisenhower but with steel communication lines to their masters, Roosevelt and Churchill: Murphy and Macmillan.

The Tunisian campaign in the winter of 1942/43 was interesting, and bloody as evidenced by no less than eight Commonwealth cemeteries. American troops and the British 1st Army were landed on the Algerian coast in November 1942 and expected to push east to take Tunis by Christmas, thus blocking Rommel's Afrika Korps which was being pushed west along the Libyan coast by Montgomery's 8th Army. Well, it did not happen quite that way. The 1st Army was held by the Germans at Longstop Hill and Kasserine, to name but two sites we will visit, by a powerful German force flown in from Italy and Sicily. The 8th Army arrived at the curve of the Tunisian penninsula at a position not unlike El Alamein where they were held up, thus forcing a delay upon total victory which did not occur till May 1943. Over 200 thousand Axis soldiers were taken on the Cape Bon penninsula, rather in excess of those at an equally pointless campaign, at Stalingrad. We will look at the road from Medjez el Bab as it winds towards Tunis City - it was here that Hannibal's elephants marched - the uses of the 1942 tank and Hannibal's elephants have much in common ! Look at the map to find where the Allies started: it is a half-moon sometimes bitterly opposed circuit from Agadir to Safi, it is the sinking, after a fierce fight, of the French battleship, "Jean Bart", and several other French ships at Casablanca, it is the battle with French troops at Maison Blanche. By midnight a frail truce was called.
Across the water Germany marched into un-occupied France and Vichy broke off relations with the USA. The way was now cleared for the final Allied North African offensive - and this is what we will study with many a disputed opinion, even more laughs and a few days in the dry Tunisian sun - interspersed with some very good dinners.

THE ITINERARY

Thursday 21st October. Individuals make their own bookings with Air France. As with our visit to Monte Cassino we found that it is too restricting to quote a price inclusive of air fares at group rates when the flight times do not always suit everyone. The main party are advised to book on AF 1284 dep. CDG at 14.55, arr. Tunis Carthage at 17.35.A transfer bus awaits us. We check in at the Hotel El Mechtel in Tunis and dine that night at Dar El Jeld Restaurant in the Medina. For those who cannot leave earlier there is a later flight AF 1784 leaving CDG at 21.05 and arriving at Tunis Carthage at 22.35. You will miss dinner in the Medina but we are checking to see if the hotel operates a courtesy collection from the airport, but you may need to take a taxi to the hotel.

Friday 22nd October. We start our tour by coach to Choulgi, El Heri (Longstop), Medjez el Bab. Then to Bou Arada. We shall take lunch en route. Then to Teboursouk where we check in at the Hotel Thugga, where we shall have Dinner.

Saturday 23rd October. We leave Teboursouk by coach and go to Le Kef, then to Kasserine; thence to Sidi Bou Zid. In the late afternoon we go to Kairouan, checking in at the Hotel la Kasbah which has a heated pool. We have Dinner in the hotel.

Sunday 24th October. Breakfast in the hotel. Transfer by coach to Tunis. Take Flight AF2585 Tunis Carthage-Paris CDG, dep. 15.05, arr. CDG at 18.40.

PACKAGE COST

The cost per head of the package described above, excluding the return air fare, and including: Airport transfer bus, 3 hotel nights, 3 dinners, 2 lunches, private coach and also including a levy to cover our guide's expenses is 380 euros. For single rooms there will be a supplement of 60 euros for three nights.

BOOKING

Members wishing to take part in this tour are invited to e-mail Roger Thorn without delay on: roger.thorn@wanadoo.fr. Their message should indicate the number of tour places to be reserved, and whether a single or double hotel room(s) is required. Also whether there any particular dietary requirements. On confirmation of their booking they will then be invited to send their cheque in advance to cover all the places to be reserved.

CLUB LUNCH REPLY SLIP

Name : _____

Address : _____

_____

Telephone Number : _____

Please reserve for me _____ *place(s) for the Club Lunch to be held on*

October 6th *October 28th* *November 25th*

*I enclose a cheque made payable to The Royal British Legion, for €*_____

Send your reply slip and cheque to : Miss Joan Hicks, 6 rue des Petits Prés, 78810 Feucherolles.

CHRISTMAS LUNCH AND CHRISTMAS DINNER

*Name :*_____

Address : _____

_____

Telephone Number : _____

Please reserve for me _____ *place(s) for the*

Christmas Lunch *Christmas Dinner*

*I enclose a cheque made payable to The Royal British Legion, for €*_____

Send your reply slip and cheque to ; Miss Joan Hicks, 6 rue des Petits Prés, 78810 Feucherolles.

THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION

THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION PARIS BRANCH

POPPY APPEAL ET COTISATIONS 2010/11
POPPY APPEAL & SUBSCRIPTIONS 2010/11

- Normal / *Normale* 46 Euros
- Reduced / *Réduite* (65 and + / *65 ans et +*) 37 Euros
- 25 years and under / *25 ans ou moins* 21 Euros

Poppy Appeal contribution
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Administrative Fund donation
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Veuillez établir votre cheque à l'ordre de "Royal British Legion"

Royal British Legion. 28 rue des Acacias 75017 PARIS . Tel 01 47 42 19 26
Website : http://www.rblfrance.org/ e-mail : paris@rblfrance.org

Massacre on the Marne

The Life & Death of the 2/5th Battalion West Yorkshire Regiment in the Great War

Fraser Skirrow

Special Offer price £15.99 **Quote Ref: 101858**

Massacre on the Marne is a graphic reconstruction of the experiences of a small closely knit group of fighting men - the 2/5th Battalion of the West Yorkshire Regiment - in the Great War. These men were not elite regular troops or Kitcheners' Men, they were Territorials. In many ways they were typical of the men who fought on the Western Front. Using the words of the men themselves, taken from their letters, diaries and memoirs as well as quotations from the reports and despatches of the time, Fraser Skirrow records how they learnt the painful lessons of trench warfare and became a highly efficient fighting unit. He also records how their hard-won efficiency was not enough to save them, for the Second Battle of the Marne in 1918 was their last - in a few terrible hours they were virtually wiped out. This meticulously researched history allows the reader to follow the careers of these men through every phase of the war, from recruitment to the final tragedy, and it makes compelling reading.

Fraser Skirrow's family served with the 2/5th West Yorkshires in the First World War. When Fraser tried to find out more about what had happened to him, he quickly exhausted published works on territorial force units and on the West Yorkshire Regiment battalions. This led to a research project that lasted for over five years. He spent months walking the battlefields of the Western Front, understanding the ground that each battle or patrol was fought on. The result is this fascinating book. Fraser Skirrow was educated at Oxford and the London Business School and he now runs an investment business.

9781844154968 **Hardback** **RRP £19.99** **288 pages**

Please send.....copy/ies of **Massacre on the Marne** at the price of **£15.99**

plus £4 postage and packing UK, £8 P+P Europe, £14 P+P for Rest of the World

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AMBERLEY PUBLISHING

FRONTSTALAG 142
THE INTERNMENT DIARY OF AN ENGLISH LADY
KATHERINE LACK



In December 1940, as the coldest winter in living memory fastened its grip on war-torn France, the Nazi conquerors rounded up nearly 5,000 people, mostly women and children, and sent them to an internment camp. Their destination, Frontstalag 142, was in the Besançon army barracks near the German border. There they remained for months in conditions so bad that many died of cold, food poisoning and disease.

The internees had only one thing in common: they all held British papers. Wealthy expatriates, holiday makers caught out by the speed of the Blitzkrieg, wives of First World War 'tommies', French nationals born in England – all were on the list. Among them were two English ladies, Miss Kathleen and Miss Fanny Twemlow – great aunts of the author.

Aunt Kathleen soon succumbed to the terrible conditions, but was hospitalised and survived. Aunt Fan remained in the camps (she was sent to a camp in Vittel after Besançon) for a year until, aged sixty, she was released. The conditions in Frontstalag 142 are revealed here in all their harrowing detail, through Aunt Fan's diary and the memoirs of some of the other survivors. Aunt Fan was an artist, and her sketches of camp life, many drawn secretly on tiny scraps of paper and kept in the family ever since, give a poignant insight into the hardships these women endured in this forgotten chapter of the war.

Publication: September 2010
Price: £20 hbk
ISBN: 978-1-4456-0055-0
128pp + 16pp colour section

ORDER FORM

Please complete the following form for *FRONTSTALAG 142* and return to Amberley Publishing
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